

Customer Support Knowledge Base Style Guide

Owning area: Customer_support

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Policy owner: Head of Customer Support Operations

1. Purpose and Overview

This guide defines how IronStore customer support knowledge base (KB) articles are written, reviewed, published, and maintained. It applies to customer-facing Help Centre content and internal agent guidance used across European markets.

The objective is to provide accurate, easy-to-scan instructions that help customers resolve common issues without contacting support. Articles must reflect current IronStore processes, product categories, delivery options, payment methods, and country-specific requirements.

The KB is maintained in **GuideHub**, with operational links to **Zendesk**, **OrderSphere**, **ReturnFlow**, and the **IronStore Product Catalogue (IPC)**. GuideHub is the authoritative source for approved support content.

2. Scope

This standard applies to:

- Public Help Centre articles, troubleshooting guides, FAQs, and policy explanations.
- Internal agent procedures, saved replies, escalation notes, and workflow instructions.
- Content created for all supported European storefronts and languages.
- New articles, major revisions, translations, and republished content.
- Content owners, subject-matter experts, translators, quality reviewers, and support agents.

This standard does not replace legal, privacy, payment-security, product-safety, or marketplace policies. Where requirements conflict, the stricter approved policy applies.

3. Content Policy and Procedures

3.1 Article selection and ownership

Create an article when a question is:

- Asked regularly through Zendesk.
- Likely to be solved without account-specific investigation.
- Relevant to more than one product, order, or country.

- Needed to explain a change in policy, system, or customer journey.

Do not publish an article for:

- A single customer's order or account details.
- Unconfirmed product information.
- Temporary incidents unless marked as a service notice.
- Advice that could create safety, legal, financial, or medical risk.

Each article must have one named **Content Owner** in GuideHub. The owner is accountable for accuracy, review dates, and updates following process changes.

3.2 Article types and required structure

Use one of the following article types:

- **How-to:** Steps the customer can complete independently.
- **Policy:** Rules for returns, refunds, delivery, payments, or accounts.
- **Troubleshooting:** Checks and actions for a specific issue.
- **FAQ:** Short answers to common questions.
- **Internal procedure:** Agent-only handling and escalation instructions.
- **Service notice:** Time-limited information about an outage or disruption.

Use this order unless there is a clear reason to vary it:

1. Descriptive title.
2. One-sentence summary of the customer outcome.
3. Eligibility or important conditions.
4. Numbered steps or short answer sections.
5. Exceptions and escalation guidance.
6. Related links.
7. Review metadata for internal articles.

Start with the answer. Do not open with background, apologies, or promotional language.

3.3 Titles, headings, and summaries

Titles must describe the customer's task or question.

Preferred:

- "How to change a delivery address"
- "When will my refund be processed?"
- "What to do if your parcel arrives damaged"

Avoid:

- “Important information about orders”
- “We are here to help”
- “Delivery FAQ and other useful information”

Use sentence case for titles and headings. Keep titles below 70 characters where possible. Use headings to separate decisions or stages, not to create unnecessary visual breaks.

The opening summary should be no more than two sentences and should state the main outcome, expected timeframe, or key restriction.

3.4 Writing style and tone

IronStore content must be clear, neutral, practical, and respectful.

Use:

- “You can request a return within 30 days of delivery.”
- “Enter the email address used for the order.”
- “We will email you when the refund is issued.”

Avoid:

- Blame: “You entered the wrong address.”
- Unclear promises: “Your parcel should arrive soon.”
- Internal language: “The ticket has been routed to L2.”
- Excessive enthusiasm, slang, or humour.
- Legalistic wording where plain language is sufficient.

Address the reader as **you** and IronStore as **we**. Use active voice and short sentences. Explain unavoidable terms at first use, for example, “proof of delivery (POD).”

Do not use:

- All-capital words for emphasis.
- Multiple exclamation marks.
- Emoji in policy or troubleshooting content.
- “Simply,” “obviously,” “guaranteed,” or “always” unless factually exact.
- Claims that a result is certain when it depends on a carrier, bank, seller, or manufacturer.

3.5 Steps, conditions, and decision points

Write instructions as numbered steps. Each step should contain one action.

- Begin with a verb: **Open, Select, Upload, Contact**.
- Name the exact button or field shown in the current interface.
- Put conditions before steps where they affect eligibility.
- State what the customer should see after completing an action.
- Include the next action if a step fails.

Use bullets for lists of requirements or examples. Use tables only when they improve comparison, such as delivery methods or refund timeframes.

For decision points, use clear “If / Then” wording:

- **If** the tracking page shows “Delivered” but you cannot find the parcel, **contact us within 48 hours**.
- **If** the item is damaged, **do not return it before uploading photographs**.

Do not direct customers to internal queues, team names, or unpublished tools.

3.6 Product, order, and policy accuracy

Before publication, verify all operational facts in the relevant system:

- Product specifications: **IPC** or the manufacturer’s approved data sheet.
- Order and delivery status: **OrderSphere** and the carrier portal.
- Return eligibility: **ReturnFlow** and the current country policy.
- Payment status: **PayCore** transaction record.
- Promotions: current campaign brief in **CampaignVault**.

Never copy customer-specific information into a public article. Do not publish full order numbers, email addresses, phone numbers, payment details, or screenshots containing personal data.

Timeframes must include the starting point:

- “Within 14 calendar days of delivery.”
- “Refunds are issued within five business days after inspection.”
- “Bank processing may take an additional three to seven business days.”

State the applicable country or storefront when rules differ. Do not use “Europe-wide” unless the Legal or Policy team has confirmed that the rule is uniform.

3.7 Returns, refunds, and delivery wording

Use the approved terminology:

- **Return request:** customer asks to send an item back.
- **Return label:** shipping label issued by IronStore or a seller.
- **Refund issued:** IronStore has released the funds.

- **Refund received:** funds are visible in the customer's account.
- **Delivery estimate:** expected date, not a guarantee.
- **Delivery guarantee:** use only where contractually confirmed.

For damaged, incorrect, or missing items, explain the evidence required and the response target. Standard guidance is:

- Customer reports damage within **48 hours** of delivery where possible.
- Customer provides photographs of the item, packaging, and shipping label.
- Support reviews the case within **two business days**.
- High-value claims above **€250** require **Customer Resolution Team** review.
- Suspected fraud, repeated claims, or safety concerns go to **Trust & Safety**.

Do not instruct customers to dispose of an item unless the case record includes an approved disposal instruction.

3.8 Accessibility and localisation

All customer-facing content must meet IronStore's accessibility baseline:

- Use descriptive link text, not "click here."
- Provide meaningful alt text for essential images.
- Do not use colour alone to communicate status.
- Keep paragraphs to four lines or fewer on standard desktop view.
- Use headings in logical order.
- Avoid screenshots when text instructions are sufficient.

Content is initially written in International English and translated through **LinguaDesk**. Localisation reviewers must check:

- Currency, date, time, and measurement formats.
- Country-specific consumer rights and delivery terms.
- Local carrier and payment names.
- Formality, terminology, and prohibited claims.

Machine or vendor translation must not be published without review by an approved language reviewer.

3.9 Links, screenshots, and system references

Use stable GuideHub links where available. Do not link directly to temporary Zendesk views, agent dashboards, or personal documents.

Screenshots must:

- Show only the relevant area.

- Use the current interface.
- Exclude personal data, internal IDs, and browser notifications.
- Include a short caption or alt text.
- Be reviewed whenever the interface changes.

Broken links, outdated images, or missing translations are content defects and must be corrected within **five business days** of identification.

3.10 Review, approval, and publication

The Content Owner completes the draft and records the source of each policy or operational claim. Required approval depends on content type:

- Standard how-to or FAQ: **Support Knowledge Manager**.
- Returns, refunds, delivery, or payment policy: **Support Operations Manager** and relevant Policy Owner.
- Privacy or personal-data content: **Privacy Counsel**.
- Product safety or regulated products: **Product Compliance Manager**.
- Country-specific legal wording: **Local Market Lead**.

The Knowledge Manager publishes approved content in GuideHub and records:

- Owner and approving roles.
- Applicable markets and languages.
- Publication date.
- Next review date.
- Related systems or policy references.

Standard articles are reviewed every **six months**. Payment, privacy, safety, and legal articles are reviewed every **three months**. Articles affected by a process or system change must be reviewed before the change goes live.

Agents should flag inaccurate or unclear content using the “**Report KB issue**” form in Zendesk. Critical errors affecting refunds, safety, privacy, or customer eligibility must be escalated to the Team Lead immediately and corrected or temporarily unpublished within **one business day**.

4. Roles and Responsibilities

- **Support Knowledge Manager:** Owns this standard, publishing controls, audits, and reporting.
- **Content Owner:** Drafts, maintains, and reviews assigned articles.
- **Subject-Matter Expert:** Confirms operational or product accuracy.
- **Local Market Lead:** Confirms country-specific language and requirements.
- **Language Reviewer:** Validates translated content in LinguaDesk.
- **Support Team Lead:** Identifies agent content gaps and urgent inaccuracies.
- **Support Agent:** Uses approved content and reports defects; does not create unapproved customer policy.

- **Policy, Legal, Privacy, or Compliance Owner:** Approves specialist content within their remit.

5. Related Documents and References

- **CS-POL-001:** Customer Contact and Escalation Policy
- **CS-POL-006:** Returns and Refunds Standard
- **CS-POL-009:** Delivery Exceptions and Carrier Claims
- **CS-SEC-003:** Customer Data Handling in Support
- **CS-QA-002:** Support Quality Review Framework
- **PC-STD-011:** Product Safety and Recall Communications
- **GuideHub Publishing Checklist**
- **IronStore Brand and Accessibility Checklist**
- **Country Storefront Policy Matrix**

6. Revision History

- **August 2026 — v3.2:** Added localisation controls, accessibility requirements, and the €250 high-value claim threshold. Updated review frequencies.
- **February 2026 — v3.1:** Clarified damaged-item evidence requirements and GuideHub ownership fields.
- **September 2025 — v3.0:** Consolidated regional KB standards and replaced legacy Confluence publishing with GuideHub.